

Home Alone

The Origin Story

Dr. John is a friend of mine who is a vet who worked in Asia for many years and then got transferred to work in Sydney a few years before COVID. His company set him up in a small unit on the ground floor in a nice Sydney suburb.

One Friday morning when he was due in for work he had a stroke while he was lying alone on his bed.

He was paralyzed. His mobile phone was beside his head but he couldn't use it. He couldn't move. He couldn't get up to go to the toilet or eat or drink.

Around 10 a.m that morning his company had realized he hadn't come to work and they tried to call him. He could hear the phone ringing but he couldn't touch the phone. He could not do anything.

Later that day his mother (living in Adelaide) had expected him to call. When he had not called, she tried to call him and didn't receive any answer. She messaged. No responses. It was very unusual for her son to ignore her calls.

Dr John was still lying alone on his bed paralyzed.

Late in the afternoon, his mother started to get worried. But Dr John was 45 years old and she thought well maybe he was busy at work that day.

Dr. John was still lying alone in his bed, paralysed. All through Friday and into Friday night.

Then all through Friday night and into Saturday morning. No water, no food, not been able to go to the toilet. Nothing.

His phone had rung a few times, but he was unable to answer. Some people had messaged, unable to reply.

He remained there on Saturday morning. In the middle of Saturday, his mother had got more worried and attempted to ring and message Dr. John again, but again no answer. So she called a family friend in Sydney and asked them to go to his apartment and see what, if anything, was wrong with Dr. John. These people initially said no. It was crazy because Dr. John was 45 years old and it would take them half an hour to drive to the house. The mother begged multiple times and eventually the friends in Sydney agreed to drive to Dr. John's house.

So they drove to Dr. John's house late on Saturday afternoon, knocked on the front door. Dr. John heard the knocks but could not respond, could not get out of bed, could not yell out, and remained on the bed. The people who knocked on the door eventually gave up, thinking that Dr. John was out, left the Dr. John's apartment and called his mother and said he appears to be out, he's 45 years old, don't worry, he'll probably contact you tomorrow.

Dr. John remained on his bed all the way through Saturday evening and into Sunday morning. Still no water, food or toilet. Still paralysed.

On Sunday morning, Dr. John's mother had become more worried because it was very unusual for Dr. John to not contact her over the space of 48 hours. And so she tried again, no answer from Dr. John who remained on the bed, still no water, no food, no toilet, completely paralyzed, his phone beside his bed, still charging because it was plugged in the whole time so it didn't run out of battery. He knew every time the phone rang or a message came that he couldn't answer.

So eventually his mother rang the family friend again and begged them to go back.

Now remember I said that Dr. John lived on the ground floor? Dr John's mother begged the people when they got to Dr. John's apartment to jump over the side gate and go and look in the back window.

So eventually this family friend did that and was able to look through the window. Luckily they saw Dr. John's feet on the end of the bed. That alerted them to there being a problem, and fearing the worst, they immediately rang the ambulance.

The ambulance came very quickly and they were able to break in and there they found Dr. John still alive. They evacuated him to hospital very quickly and he was treated.

The good news conclusion is that he's made a full recovery now. He no longer works full-time as a vet but he does help out in the Adelaide Zoo. He lives alone in Adelaide now near to his mother. He can drive a car by himself and he has even had a couple of international holidays by himself since that time.

It was a near miss and horrible situation. Dr John had been alone on his bed paralyzed from Friday morning until Sunday afternoon.

So I investigated the number of these cases. It turns out that in Japan only, in 2024, somewhere between 60,000 to 80,000 people died at home alone. Many are not found for days, weeks or even months. Most old people who have an injury or even stroke and heart attack do not die immediately, meaning there is a chance that they can be saved.

In Japan they even have a word for it - KodoKushi. The problem is only getting bigger around the world post COVID. Something needs to be done to stop people suffering, dying and even being unfound for days, weeks or months. Home Alone is the solution.